anything fractionally short. Over by over, run by run, I reach the 90s.

Hoggard runs in to bowl, and the ball is short and inviting. I manage to pull over mid-wicket for six, taking my score to 98; sitting in the stands, my father is particularly pleased with the stroke.

Two runs needed for a Test century. An over passes. Another over passes. I try to force the ball into the leg side for two, but succeed only in getting a leading edge that thankfully lands safely. Jacques is watching sympathetically and he walks down the pitch between overs. 'Keep calm, youngster,' he says. 'It will come, it will come.'

And it does come. Simon Jones bowls wide of off stump. I get into position and play the square cut, sending the ball speeding to the boundary, taking my score into three figures. I am eventually out for 109 in just over four and a half hours of careful batting.

The century feels good, but when England bat again there is no time to take the 10 wickets required to force the win. They do lose four wickets, but the fifth Test ends in a draw and the series is lost 2–1.

Our changing room is quiet after the match. We are disappointed by the defeat. However, sitting at SuperSport Park, among the Proteas, all these senior players, these heroes and legends, I feel personally satisfied and relieved, I feel as though I have made a decent contribution to the side, as though I'm worth my place – as though I belong.